

MeeGo ready for handsets

The successor to both Intel's Moblin Linux and Nokia's Maemo, and the product of an exciting partnership, MeeGo was released in developer form two and half months ago. Soon after, they released a Moblin-inspired netbook version of MeeGo, and now, they have made the Maemo-inspired handset version available to the public, complete with a UI. It is currently compatible with the Nokia N900 and Intel's own Aava Mobile platform based on Moorsetown.

Symbian has been struggling to keep up with the other platforms, and even Symbian^3 in an exhaustive review of the OS by Mobile Review only seemed to be playing catch up. But in MeeGo lies a new hope. If Nokia does drop Symbian from its higher end N-series devices – as they supposedly are – Nokia might have better luck with its smartphones with a more capable OS.

The plans for MeeGo don't



end here. With MeeGo Intel and Nokia plan to increase the scope of their merged Linux distribution from Netbooks (for Intel's Moblin), and smartphones/internet tablets (for Nokia's Maemo) to five categories of devices: netbooks, handsets, media players, in-vehicle infotainment systems, and televisions. On the other hand, Android too, is growing and has been demonstrated in all kinds of devices, from netbooks, numerous handsets, tablets, cars, media players, and of course, TVs with Google's own Google TV. MeeGo has a lot of competition ahead to face.

All four of these operating systems (Moblin, Maemo, MeeGo and Android) are Linux based, and all of them do their own thing UI-wise. While one may feel like declaring a winner, and the "death" of the other platform, the best thing for consumers is choice. We now have the luxury of choices for PC operating systems, and as these devices get more powerful and more featured, we may see a future where the choice of a mobile device will be uncoupled from that of a mobile OS.

On a related note, Nokia is gearing up fight for a place in the smartphone market with

MeeGo and Symbian^3, with Nokia CEO Anssi Vanjoki telling the world that he and his company are committed to make Nokia "number one for high-end devices". He also praised MeeGo as the future of the smartphone era: "The current phase of MeeGo development is looking awesome. We believe it will power the computers of the future. And the computers of the future will not be tied to a desk or even a lap – they will fit in your pocket..."

With MeeGo, Nokia might actually succeed and manage to produce Nokia's new dream of "killer smartphones and market-changing mobile computers." Vanjoki also said that Nokia has "no plans to introduce an Android device", and that they'd be sticking to Symbian and MeeGo.

Refer to www.thinkdigit.com/latest/MeeGo.html for more images as well as videos of the interface.

Sony Ericsson Vivaz Pro: Loses 8MP

We particularly loved the original Vivaz for one thing: 720p continuous autofocus video recording ability in a slender, sexy body. It is still there in the Vivaz Pro. We particularly hated the original Vivaz for another thing: Symbian S60 5th edition, which has now been completely run over by the newer touch-oriented operating systems. Unfortunately, this too is still there.

The form factor is the same as the Vivaz, with Sony Ericsson's Human Curvature design. The

back panel is a hard plastic with a fine dull finish, which gives it an appearance of solidity. In fact, it is not until you remove the back panel that you realise that it is actually quite flimsy. The power button (that doubles as screen-lock toggle) rests in an odd position, on the upper half of the back panel. The three function buttons (select, call answer and call cancel) placed below the screen, and the volume controls on the side, are all thin but easy on the fingers and tactile. We also like the two dedicated buttons on the side, for Video and Photo

mode. The screen is the same as Vivaz; 640 x 360 with high dpi of 229. The slider is spring-loaded and is somewhere between the snappy N97 mini and the manual Motorola Milestone. We liked the slider of the Vivaz Pro.

The 5MP camera of the phone still manages to record 720p video. This feature needs a little clarification though: while the camera has been downgraded, it is still more than enough for the 720p video recording, 8 megapixels are not really needed for the 720p recording.

Although the touch is bad, the



hardware QWERTY is the saving grace here, as it saves us from the torture that was on-screen typing on the Vivaz. We'd give the keyboard a lot of marks for looks, as each key has backlit borders that lend a splendid effect. But, ergonomic-wise, the keyboard just scrapes through.